

TB Exciter

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Overview

Opens a dull top end and adds air, clarity, and controlled harmonic detail without pulling the original sound apart.

What this plug-in solves

A high-shelf EQ can only turn up brightness that is already present, and full-band saturation can blur the source while trying to add detail. TB Exciter keeps the original signal intact and adds a dedicated upper-frequency layer, giving musicians and sound designers a fast way to reveal air, articulation, and polish without rebuilding the whole tone.

What you can expect

- A clearer, more open top end without thinning the source
- A choice between rounded warmth and crisp harmonic definition
- Stereo expansion that affects only the added upper-frequency layer
- Fast starting points for mixes, vocals, drums, and instruments

How it works

TB Exciter keeps the original signal intact and builds a separate upper-frequency layer beside it. That layer combines a smooth opening of the top end with low-level new harmonics, so the result can reveal detail that a simple high-shelf boost cannot create while avoiding the broad tonal change of full-band saturation.

Bright sets how much of the added layer is heard, Clarity changes its harmonic texture from round and warm toward light and clear, and Focus decides whether it begins in the presence region or stays around the highest air. Width spreads only the added layer, while Level finishes the gain match without moving the original stereo center.

Quick start

- 1 Choose Factory Default or a source-specific Factory preset.
- 2 Raise or lower Bright until the top end opens without becoming the main event.
- 3 Move Focus to decide whether the effect supports presence and attack or only the highest air.
- 4 Use Clarity to choose a rounder glow or a cleaner sparkle.
- 5 Adjust Width only on stereo material, then use Level to match the bypassed loudness.
- 6 Listen in the complete arrangement and save the session once the source keeps its original role.

Interface and key sections



This is a direct capture of the current plug-in interface. Use the visible labels to locate the areas and controls explained below.

Bright, Clarity, and Focus

Bright sets how much upper-frequency detail is added. Clarity moves the new harmonic texture from round and warm toward light and clear. Focus decides whether the effect reaches down into presence and attack or stays concentrated on air and sheen.

Width and Level

Width changes only the stereo spread of the added upper-frequency layer, leaving the original center and placement intact. Level trims the completed result for headroom and a fair bypass comparison.

Factory preset selector

Thirty Factory presets are organized into Essential, Mix / Master, Vocal, Drums, and Instruments groups. Editing a loaded preset adds an asterisk to its name; selecting it again restores its original values.

Factory preset collection

Essential: Factory Default, Barely There, Soft Gold, Mono Sparkle, Open Air, Dark Track Rescue.
Mix / Master: Mix Bus Polish, Mix Bus Clarity, Warm Master Silk, Clear Master Air,
Dense Mix Unveil, Vintage Top Glue. Vocal: Lead Vocal Air, Intimate Vocal Glow,
Female Vocal Shine, Male Vocal Presence, Background Vocal Wide, Breath & Whisper. Drums:
Drum Bus Snap, Snare Crack, Cymbal Silk, Cymbal Detail, Percussion Wide, Lo-Fi Hats Restore.
Instruments: Acoustic String Detail, Electric Guitar Edge, Piano Hammer Air, Synth Halo,
Bass Definition, Orchestral Sheen.

Active Readout and Sparkle Field

The center readout shows the currently selected control and its value. The animated Sparkle Field reflects the five control settings as visual feedback; it is not an input spectrum or level meter.

Knob interaction and session recall

Drag vertically to adjust a knob and double-click it to return to its Factory default. Controls include keyboard focus, accessible names, descriptions, and tooltips. The DAW session recalls all five control values and the selected Factory preset state.

Bypass

The DAW bypass provides a direct comparison while keeping the processing path aligned. Match the final listening level with Level before deciding whether the added brightness is genuinely helping.

Controllable properties

The guide uses the names shown on the plug-in panel. Each explanation describes the audible result, a useful way to approach the control, and an important interaction to listen for.

Control	What it does and when to use it
Bright	Sets how much of the dedicated upper-frequency layer is added beside the original signal. Set this first. Raise it until the source opens, then back away if breath, hiss, cymbals, or consonants begin to dominate.
Bypass	Turns the complete effect off or on for a direct before-and-after comparison. Match Level first, then compare the same short passage with bypass so extra loudness is not mistaken for better tone.
Clarity	Changes the added harmonic texture from round and warm toward light, clear, and sparkling. Choose the texture after Bright and Focus are close. Lower it for rounded polish; raise it for a lighter, more explicit edge.
Focus	Chooses where the upper-frequency layer begins. Lower settings reach presence and attack; higher settings concentrate on air and sheen. Move it lower when presence and attack need help, or higher when only air and sheen should change.
Level	Sets the final output level after the original and added layers are combined. Use it for headroom and a fair bypass comparison; the plug-in does not include a final limiter.
Width	Changes only the stereo spread of the added upper-frequency layer while leaving the original image in place. Use it on stereo material after the tone is settled, and check mono before keeping an extreme spread.

Practical uses

Mix or master polish

- Begin with Mix Bus Polish, Warm Master Silk, or Clear Master Air.
- Use a restrained Bright setting and keep Focus in the upper part of the source.
- Keep Width close to the original image and match Level carefully against bypass.

Expected result: The mix feels more open and finished while its center, low end, and overall balance remain stable.

Air for the main vocal

- Start with Lead Vocal Air or Intimate Vocal Glow.
- Use Focus to separate useful breath and articulation from harsh consonants.
- Choose Clarity to suit the voice, then keep Width restrained so the vocal remains firmly centered.

Expected result: Words and breath read more clearly without making the voice feel disconnected from the mix.

Backing vocal or pad halo

- Choose Background Vocal Wide or Synth Halo.
- Set Bright and Clarity before widening the added layer.
- Increase Width only until the center has room and the stereo edges remain stable in mono.

Expected result: The added high texture surrounds the main sound while the original source remains firmly centered.

Acoustic detail

- Begin with Acoustic String Detail or Piano Hammer Air.
- Lower Focus until picking, strings, or hammer detail becomes easier to read.
- Back Bright away if handling noise or room hiss begins to attract attention.

Expected result: Small performance details return without turning the instrument into a brittle or over-processed layer.

Dark track rescue

- Begin with Dark Track Rescue or Bass Definition.
- Move Focus lower to reach presence as well as air.
- Use a clearer Clarity setting only if the source still needs definition, then reduce Level for headroom.

Expected result: A veiled source moves forward and becomes easier to place without losing its low-frequency weight.

Common pitfalls

TB Exciter is not a de-esser or noise remover; hiss, sibilance, and rough cymbals may become more noticeable as the top end opens. Control the problem first with editing, EQ, or de-essing, then add only the brightness the cleaned source can support.

If the added layer sounds like a separate distortion effect, the processing is stronger than the source can support. Lower Bright first, then move Clarity toward the rounder side before changing the rest of the sound.

Width changes only the added stereo layer and therefore has little practical effect on a mono source. Judge Width on stereo material and use Bright, Focus, and Clarity for meaningful changes on mono sources.

There is no internal limiter; strong Bright, Width, and Level settings can use more headroom than expected. Reduce Level and leave output headroom before increasing Bright or Width again.

Extra loudness can make any setting seem more impressive even when the tone is not better. Trim Level until bypassed and active playback feel equally loud, then compare tone and detail.